somewhat akin to the Haj subsidies the Union government had paid for decades, until 2018.[26] 'There was a time when such things [iftar] were a necessity,' said a UP MLA. 'Not anymore.' Once party leaders saw that ending such symbolic moves did not harm them electorally, they saw no reason to rethink the strategy. 'The fact that BJP started winning in Muslim-dominated seats shows that parties had been wrong earlier about the supposed power of the Muslim vote. They were not that big as people thought,' the MLA said.

Contrary to received wisdom, many leaders in UP emphatically made the point to me that one reason why support for the SP and the BSP declined was because they gave so much importance to Muslim representation. The SP in 2017 fielded sixty-five Muslims (20.7 per cent of its candidates), the BSP fielded as many as ninety-eight (24.4 per cent). 'Elections are won by karyakartas [workers],' one Opposition MLA told me. 'They make the *chunaav ki haava. Chunaav ko charhate hai* [the election's momentum. They make the election rise]. If my top ten guys get angry and stay at home, then *chunaav nahi charhega* [the election momentum won't rise]. If Muslims are fielded by SP in, say, Meerut and such places, then it is an issue. *Unka chunaav charhta nahin hai* [their election momentum does not rise]. BJP has an advantage there. Politics has changed in the last seven years. Cadres have shifted. SP is not growing. The committed BSP cadre of old who used to wear a blanket and be out on the road for a month on cycles are not doing that anymore. While cadres of other parties are depressed, BJP guys are on a high.'[27] While representation matters a great deal in electoral democracy, for many political leaders, the metric of success is winnability. On that metric, the BJP's punt worked.

How do these larger debates on secularism, the place of Muslims and their gradual marginalisation play out in the village? When we asked Chouhan, the village pradhan in Saharanpur, to compare Yogi Adityanath with his predecessor, Akhilesh Yadav, the answer was clear. The 'biggest impact has been on law and order at the panchayati level,' he said. 'No community is able to be haavi [dominant] on the other, whether Muslim or Hindu. Earlier, Muslim leaders, especially in western UP, were very haavi. There were local leaders here who had clout in police stations and Hindus wouldn't